



TRANSPORTATION



Joby Aviation to buy  
Blade Air Mobility's  
rideshare business



Kirsten Korosec — 4:18 AM PDT · August 4, 2025

Electric air taxi developer Joby Aviation has agreed to buy Blade Air Mobility's helicopter rideshare business for as much as \$125 million.

Joby is buying the Blade brand and the company's passenger business, which includes operations in the United States and Europe. Blade founder and CEO Rob Wiesenathel will continue to lead the business, which will operate as a wholly-owned subsidiary of Joby.

Blade's medical division, which transports organs, isn't included in the transaction and will remain a separate company.

IMAGE CREDITS: JOBY

The deal gives Joby instant access to a network of 12 terminals in key markets like New York City — notably, a dedicated lounge as well as terminal bases at John F. Kennedy International Airport, Newark Liberty Airport, the West Side of Manhattan, the East Side of Manhattan, and Wall Street.

Blade, founded in 2014, doesn't own a fleet of aircraft. Instead, the company has developed a digital network that allows passengers to book private rides on helicopters across several short-hop routes. The service has grown in popularity as well-heeled customers seek ways to avoid traffic on their commutes from the suburbs into Manhattan, or to The Hamptons for weekends and holidays. The company, which also offers access to

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routes from Nice, France, to Monaco and Saint-Tropez, flew more than 50,000 passengers in 2024.

Joby Aviation founder and CEO Joe Ben Bevirt described the deal as a “strategically important” acquisition that will support its launch of its commercial operations in Dubai and subsequent global rollout. The company said it will integrate its software, which is designed to manage air taxi operations, into Blade’s passenger service.

Joby, founded in 2009 by Bevirt, has been working for more than a decade to develop, certify, and produce an electric vertical take off and landing (eVTOL) aircraft for commercial taxi service in cities. (The company is also pursuing a separate [defense-related business](#).) Eventually, the branded Blade service will use electric air taxis, not helicopters, in its service, according to the companies.

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Toyota-backed Joby [went public](#) in 2021 through a merger with Reinvent Technology Partners, a

special purpose acquisition company backed by LinkedIn co-founder Reid Hoffman and Zynga founder Mark Pincus.

Under terms of the agreement, Joby is holding back \$35 million of the purchase price, which will be released if Blade hits certain performance milestones and retains certain key employees.

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Toyota pours another \$500M into electric air



# taxi startup Joby Aviation

Kirsten Korosec — 5:48 AM PDT · October 2, 2024

Toyota is doubling down on Joby Aviation with a \$500 million investment into the California-based company that's developing electric air taxis. Toyota's total investment in Joby, which includes a [\\$394 million](#) capital injection back in 2020, is now \$894 million.

The funds will be used to help Joby complete the lengthy Type 2 certification process with the Federal Aviation Administration and support commercial production of its electric vertical takeoff and landing aircraft. Joby is in the fourth of five stages of the type certification and aims to launch a commercial air taxi business in 2025. The company also recently rolled its third aircraft off its pilot production line in Marina, California, and broke ground on an expanded facility in California that will more than double its manufacturing footprint.

The companies said the investment will be made in two equal tranches in the form of cash for common stock. The first amount is expected to close later this year and the second in 2025.

Joby, which was founded in 2009 by Joe Ben Bevirt, has been working for more than a decade to develop, certify and produce an eVTOL aircraft that will be used as a commercial taxi service in cities.

IMAGE CREDITS: JOBY AVIATION

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Joby has become more visible in the past five years as it made progress on its eVTOL development and made high-profile financial moves.

In 2020, [Joby acquired Uber’s air taxi moonshot Elevate](#) as part of a complex deal. Under the terms, Uber offloaded Elevate to Joby Aviation and invested \$75 million into the startup. The two companies also expanded an existing partnership. A year later, Joby announced plans to [become a public company](#) through a merger with Reinvent Technology Partners, a special purpose acquisition company from well-known investor and LinkedIn co-founder Reid Hoffman and Zynga founder Mark Pincus.

The company also gained a number of backers along the way — notably Toyota, which made its first investment into Joby via its the early-stage venture capital arm Toyota Ventures.

Toyota has invested more than just cash into Joby. Since 2019, the automaker has shared with Joby the inner workings of the Toyota Production System that covers the planning, developing a manufacturing method and tooling design. Toyota engineers now work side-by-side with the Joby team in California, according to the two companies. In 2023, the companies signed a long-term agreement for Toyota to supply key powertrain and actuation components for the production of Joby’s aircraft.

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“Today’s investment builds on nearly seven years of collaboration between our companies,” Bevirt said in a statement. “The knowledge and support shared by Toyota has been instrumental in Joby’s success and we look forward to deepening our relationship as we deliver on our shared vision for the future of air travel.”

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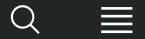
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IMAGE CREDITS: JOBY AVIATION

## air taxi service in South Korea

Rebecca Bellan — 5:52 PM PST · February 6, 2022

California-based electric vertical takeoff and landing startup Joby Aviation plans to offer an air taxi service in South Korea in partnership with SK Telecom (SKT), one of the country's largest telecommunication companies. The two partners signed a strategic collaboration agreement on Sunday at Joby's manufacturing facility in Marina, California.

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To provide better integration between land and air travel, the air taxi service will leverage the T Map Mobility platform — an SKT-spinoff that provides subscription-based mobility-as-a-service consisting of rental cars, parking, ride-hailing and other transportation-related services — and the UT ride-hailing service, a joint venture formed between T Map and Uber last year, [eight years after the Silicon Valley-based ride-hailing giant first attempted to enter the Korean market.](#)

Joby and Uber’s history goes back to 2019 when the two joined forces to boost Uber’s plans to launch an urban air taxi service. In 2020, Uber invest \$50 million in Joby’s Series C, plus [an additional \\$75 million](#) in a transaction that included the acquisition of Uber Elevate, Uber’s aerial ride-sharing unit, by Joby and an expansion of their partnership. As a result of these partnerships, Joby’s ride-sharing services will be offered to passengers through either the Joby or the Uber app when it launches in U.S. markets — Joby has said it plans to launch a commercial service in the U.S. by 2024. It is therefore likely that South Korean users will see a similar app integration with UT.

While SKT and Joby are currently seeking certification from the South Korean government, according to an SKT spokesperson, they do not yet have plans for when or where they plan to launch the air taxi service. However, a statement released by the companies expresses support of the South Korean Ministry of Land, Infrastructure and Transport’s Korean Urban Air Mobility (K-UAM) [Roadmap](#), which sets a goal of commercializing limited UAM services by 2025 in order to reduce traffic congestion in major cities. The plan is to begin with one or two routes in the Seoul metropolitan area and get up to 10 air taxi terminals by the end of the decade, all of which would connect to local buses, subways and other forms of mobility.

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SKT is a member of “UAM Team Korea,” a government-led consortium of private sector stakeholders, like Hyundai, Korean Air and Incheon International Airport Corporation, to push for the early stabilization of domestic UAM.

“With more than 42 million people living in urban areas, South Korea offers a remarkable opportunity for Joby to make air travel a part of daily life, helping people to save time while reducing their carbon footprint,” said Joe Ben Bevirt, CEO of Joby, in a statement.

Even as Joby makes moves in South Korea, the company is targeting opportunities at home. Just last week, [TechCrunch reported that Joby is seeking permission from the FCC for a series of air taxi flights over San Francisco Bay](#) to test its second-gen pre-production prototype, the S4, which has a max range of 150 miles and a top speed of 200 miles per hour. The company also claims it has a low noise profile that would allow it to access built-up areas.



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## The air taxi market prepares to take flight



Electric air mobility is gaining elevation. But there's going to be some turbulence ahead.



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## Wisk Aero and Blade Urban Air Mobility partner to bring electric air taxi services to the skies

Aria Alamalhodaei — 8:29 AM PDT · May 5, 2021

Once the design, manufacturing and certification of electric aircraft is complete, urban air mobility companies face a cascade of logistical issues, including building an app that can connect customers to rides and finding dedicated take-off and landing areas.

A new partnership between autonomous air taxi developer Wisk Aero and air mobility ride platform

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Blade Urban Air Mobility aims to provide a solution.

Under the terms of the agreement, Wisk will own and operate up to 30 aircraft on Blade’s network of dedicated air terminals along short-distance routes. Wisk will be compensated based on flight time, along anticipated minimum flight-hour guarantees, the companies said in a news release Wednesday.

It’s a smart move for both companies. Blade does not own aircraft itself, but instead brokers private air travel service through a digital platform. However, the craft they offer are conventional rotorcraft, such as helicopters and seaplanes. The partnership will help “accelerate Blade’s transition from conventional rotorcraft to safe, quiet, emission-free Electric Vertical Aircraft,” Rob Wiesenthal, CEO of Blade, said in a statement.

Wisk, born out of a joint venture between Kitty Hawk and Boeing, will be able to benefit from Blade’s experience as an air mobility service provider. Once Wisk achieves certification from the U.S. Federal Aviation Administration, it will be able to immediately ramp up via Blade’s network.

The companies say they are committed to an “open-network” approach to Urban Air Mobility, with Wisk providing aircraft to multiple customer platforms and likewise Blade using many different electric aircraft developers for its ride services. Not all electric vertical take-off and landing companies will likely take the partnership route. Joby Aviation CEO Joe Ben Bevirt has stated publicly that the company intends to be vertically integrated between its vehicle development and air taxi operations.

Blade is one of a suite of air mobility companies, including Joby, that have announced its intention to go public via a merger with a special purpose

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acquisition company. In December 2020 Blade said it would merge with SPAC Experience Investment Corp. at a valuation of \$825 million. The deal includes \$400 million in gross proceeds and \$125 million in private investment in public equity (PIPE).

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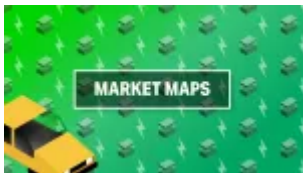
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## Can solid state batteries power up for the next generation of EVs?



As the market for EVs shifts to include commercial vehicles, aerospace, off-roaders and microtransit, the commercial future for SSBs is finally looking a little more solid.

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